enriching to get to know Ricky better and understand his perspectives on the game. I also enjoyed opening the batting with Sanath Jayasuriya in IPL season two, Shikhar Dhawan in season three and Dwayne Smith in season five.

The transformation in player relations has also had a knock-on effect on spectator behaviour at IPL matches. For example, when Shane Warne, playing for the Rajasthan Royals, rushed to congratulate the Indian all-rounder Yusuf Pathan after his Super Over heroics against the Kolkata Knight Riders in South Africa in 2009, the large Indian diaspora at the stadium was spontaneous in applauding Warne for his gesture.

Perhaps the biggest benefit of the IPL, however, is that it offers the Indian domestic cricketer an opportunity to play with the best in the world. There are plenty of players in India who are good but have narrowly missed the opportunity to represent their country. Some of them might be on the wrong side of thirty and have little hope of playing for their country. The IPL has given a lot of these players recognition unthinkable a few years earlier, as well as respect and a good income. The IPL is the best platform after international cricket at the moment, with a massive presence of international stars, and the Indian domestic players get a share of the glory associated with the international game by playing in the IPL. IPL performances are covered in detail in the media and the status of the domestic Indian cricketer has improved as a result.

Young rookies cutting their teeth in Twenty20 cricket have also benefited from the competition. To be able to face up to Dale Steyn or Morne Morkel in the nets, share a dressing room with Jacques Kallis, AB de Villiers or Kevin Pietersen, practise and play alongside the likes of Chris Gayle or Michael Hussey is a dream come true for Indian youngsters. They have a chance to learn from the greats of the contemporary game. In the Mumbai Indians, the youngsters can play in the nets against one of the best Twenty20 bowlers in the world in Lasith Malinga, rub shoulders with the likes of Kieron Pollard and discuss bowling techniques with Anil Kumble, the mentor of the team. I absolutely loved it when Malinga, fielding at mid on, walked up to Dhawal Kulkarni, the Mumbai medium-fast bowler, and offered him tips. These are gains that go far beyond the monetary riches offered by the IPL. For established Indian players, there are other benefits to be had. Invaluable knowledge about the strengths and weaknesses of players